

Service Excellence Suite Reference Guide

Communication Skills | Customer Service | Conflict Resolution

THE FOUNDATION: WHY SERVICE EXCELLENCE MATTERS HERE

AJFC clients arrive carrying more than their presenting need. They carry frustration, uncertainty, and often a history of systems that did not deliver. Service excellence in a Community Action Agency is not about scripts or pleasantries. It is about ensuring that every interaction restores dignity, builds trust, and moves the client closer to stability. Communication, service quality, and conflict resolution are not three separate skills. They are one integrated competency.

PART 1: COMMUNICATION — THE HEAR FRAMEWORK

Most people listen to respond. Active listening means listening to understand fully, before you reply.

H	Halt	Stop everything. Put down the form, stop typing, close the other screen. Give this person your full attention. Clients know when they only have part of you.
E	Engage	Use body language and verbal cues to signal presence. Nod. Maintain eye contact. On a call, use verbal cues deliberately: "I understand" and "Go on."
A	Anticipate	Resist the urge to solve before the person finishes. Stay curious. The most important thing someone needs to say is often the last thing they say.
R	Reflect	Before responding, reflect back what you heard. "What I'm hearing is..." This confirms understanding and shows respect.

HEAR applies in every direction:

- With clients: Let them finish before you respond or problem-solve.
- With colleagues: Receive feedback, handoffs, and updates with the same attention you give clients.
- In writing: Read communications fully before acting. What you miss affects your clients and your accuracy.
- When unclear: Ask. Silence is not the same as understanding. Confirm before you act.

PART 2: CUSTOMER SERVICE — THE HEART FRAMEWORK

Service excellence at AJFC is four things you always control: Dignity, Clarity, Follow-through, and Presence.

H	Hear	Let the client speak fully without interruption. Do not begin solving until you have fully received what they came to say.
E	Empathize	Acknowledge the emotional reality of their situation. "I understand this has been stressful" is not agreement — it is recognition.

A	Apologize	When the client has experienced an error, a delay, or inconsistency, a genuine apology restores dignity and trust.
R	Resolve	Be specific about what you can do and what the next step is. "I can't" without an alternative is not resolution.
T	Thank	Thank the client for their patience, their time, and their willingness to engage. It closes the interaction with dignity.

Trauma-informed service delivery means:

- Assuming past system failures, not bad intent, when a client is reactive or guarded.
- Moving clients to a private space when emotions are elevated — dignity matters in public settings.
- Keeping your language plain, your tone steady, and your follow-through consistent.
- Recognizing that for some clients, this interaction is a test of whether systems can be trusted.

PART 3: CONFLICT RESOLUTION — THE CALM FRAMEWORK

Conflict is rarely about the form, the policy, or the wait time. It is almost always about unmet need, unheard pain, or unclear expectations.

C	Calm Yourself First	Take a breath. Lower your voice and slow your pace before responding to an escalated client or colleague. Escalated responses escalate situations.
A	Acknowledge the Feeling	"I can see you are frustrated and I want to help." Acknowledgment signals you see the person, not just the problem.
L	Listen for the Real Need	Ask: "Help me understand what you need most right now." The presenting issue is rarely the real issue.
M	Move to a Solution	Be specific about what you can do and what the next step is. Vague agreements do not resolve conflict — clear next steps do.

HEALTHY CONFLICT	UNHEALTHY CONFLICT
Focuses on the issue, not the person Addresses concerns directly and respectfully Invites different perspectives and solutions Strengthens relationships when handled well	Targets the person's character, not the behavior Relies on gossip, avoidance, or repeated tension Escalates instead of moving toward resolution Damages trust and team cohesion over time

"Every client interaction is an opportunity. Show someone what it feels like to be truly heard." ~ Nicole L. Turner